Openhearted, Not Unguarded

Building Healthy Connections in Recovery

Recovery depends on connection, trust, and vulnerability. Everyone deserves to feel welcome, respected, and safe participating in our fellowship.

Not everyone will treat others with the care they deserve. Harm can take many forms, from discrimination and unwanted attention to manipulation, harassment, and exploitation.

We can be openhearted without being unguarded.

Safety isn't only about responding when something goes wrong. It's also about building the connections, judgment, and resilience that help us navigate relationships without losing our connection to recovery.

Resilience isn't about making ourselves invulnerable. It's developing the relationships and capacities that make vulnerability sustainable.

Four Principles for Navigating Relationships in Recovery

A. Build connections. Develop support across more than one person or circle, so you have room to question relationships, work through difficulties, or step back without putting your whole support system at stake.

B. Practice discernment. Notice what is shaping your choices and how you are shaping someone else's. Examine feelings, needs, assumptions, and the influence you have on one another.

C. Respect autonomy. Your needs and boundaries matter, as do other people's. Express your choices, respect others' choices, and exercise your influence with care.

D. Seek support. Draw on others for perspective, help, and connection. Make room for repair when appropriate, and for protection when needed.

These are practices to return to, not steps you have to complete in order.

A. Build a Broad Support Network

When most of our support comes from one or two people, or a single circle, questioning a relationship can feel like risking our whole social world. We may feel pressure to convince ourselves everything is fine because the alternative seems too costly. Connections across people and circles give us other sources of support while we question, disagree, work through difficulties, or take space.

Make room for connection. Say hello, introduce yourself, invite someone into a conversation, or ask whether they would like to join you. If you already know people, help others find a way in. Conversation, shared activities, small service tasks, and quiet company can all be ways to participate. An invitation should remain an invitation, not an expectation.

Keep showing up, and let trust grow through experience. Check in, follow up, and make time for ordinary conversation and shared enjoyment, not only discussions of problems. Let relationships grow at their own pace. Pay attention to reliability, mutual respect, and how people respond when needs or preferences differ.

A. Build a Broad Support Network (continued)

Share in a general way. You don't have to share everything with anyone, and neither does anyone else. You can describe an interaction in broad terms, how it affected you, and what you're trying to understand without naming people or revealing the surrounding details of your life. That includes particulars about your habits, hobbies, work, home, and relationships. Keep what happened distinct from what you think it means. **Share what matters to understanding the experience, without sharing every circumstance around it.** You can choose when to say more and to whom, particularly when specifics matter to the support you need.

Listen, give, and receive. Be curious about the person, not just their problems. Listen to understand, and ask rather than assume what would help. You can ask for what you need, and others can be honest about what they can offer. Offer what you genuinely can, and let others contribute to your life, too.

Reciprocity doesn't require keeping score or giving equally at every moment. **You don't have to earn care by being useful.** Keep the commitments you freely make, or communicate when they need to change. **Accepting support doesn't create a debt of personal access.**

Cultivate both breadth and depth. Build connections with more than one person, at a pace that works for you. Get to know people in different parts of the fellowship, so your support doesn't depend on any one person or circle. Some relationships may become close, while others remain casual. Both have value. People aren't interchangeable, but belonging needn't depend entirely on one relationship.

Make room for repair, not just harmony. When contact is safe and welcome, a small misunderstanding may call for a small repair: "I interrupted you. I'm sorry. Please finish," or "I think we've misunderstood each other. Can we try again?" You can pause a difficult conversation and, when both people want to continue, agree on how to return to it. When you're open to repair, you can acknowledge an effort to reconnect without pretending everything is resolved.

When both people are willing to address a hurt or breach of trust, listen to how the other person experienced it, acknowledge your actions and their impact, and discuss what would help put things right. Own your part without taking responsibility for what someone else did. Repair may involve clearing up a misunderstanding, respecting a limit, changing an agreement, or handling a similar situation differently. Follow through on what you've agreed, and notice whether it addresses what went wrong. A return to warmth doesn't, by itself, mean the problem has been addressed.

Repair doesn't require continuing the relationship, and healing doesn't require resolving everything together. Mutual repair may not be possible, now or ever. We can still tend to our own side: take responsibility for what is ours, make amends when appropriate, seek support for what has hurt us, and decide how to move forward. We don't have to keep pursuing a shared resolution or put our recovery on hold. Forgiveness, renewed trust, and continued contact are not things an apology entitles us to receive. **Not everything can or will be resolved.**

A difficult or harmful experience with one person needn't become your whole experience of recovery.

B. Practice Discernment

Some of us have learned to see danger everywhere; others have learned to overlook danger, even when it's right in front of us. We may do some of both in different situations.

Where you're frequently alarmed, practice distinguishing discomfort from danger. Where you've learned to suppress discomfort, practice recognizing when something may be wrong even when everything seems fine.

Neither your feelings nor their absence tells the whole story. Notice your reactions, or lack of reactions, without automatically accepting or dismissing them.

B. Practice Discernment (continued)

Notice what feels especially rewarding, too. Attention, affection, validation, and belonging can shape our judgment. Something can feel good without being good for us.

Look at what's happening. Ask yourself: *What happened? What am I assuming it means? What do I need?*

When a relationship feels confusing, compelling, or consequential, consider these four lenses from both perspectives. They are questions to explore, not a test that determines whether someone is good or bad.

Lens	My choices	My effect on others
Freedom	Can I express what I want, disagree, slow down, say no, or change my mind? What makes those choices feel automatic or difficult?	Am I leaving room for the other person to want something different, set the pace, say no, or change their mind? Can they do so without being pressed to reassure me or justify themselves?
Stakes	What would I feel I'd **risk** by saying no? Might I face anger, or lose affection, approval, belonging, or practical support? What makes me expect that consequence?	What might this person feel they risk by disappointing me? Am I using their attachment, gratitude, admiration, or reliance on me as leverage?
Drives	What old patterns or present needs might be shaping my response? Is attention, reassurance, attraction, or belonging changing what I'm willing to overlook, accept, or do?	What am I trying to satisfy through this interaction? Am I making someone else responsible for my reassurance, self-worth, gratification, or sense of control?
Influence	How is this connection shaping what I want and expect? Do I understand what the other person wants and is offering, as well as how their attention makes me feel?	What can I anticipate, because of my experience or position, that they may not? Am I being clear about what I want and can offer, or relying on their misunderstanding, trust, or vulnerability to get the response I want?

Treat your answers about another person's experience as possibilities, not facts. Listen to what they tell you, ask where appropriate, and remain willing to revise your understanding.

Good intentions don't guarantee a welcome impact, and a welcome response doesn't settle whether we're treating someone well. Notice not only how a relationship feels in the moment, but how it affects wellbeing, freedom, and connection over time.

Consider whether the connection leaves room to question, disagree, maintain other relationships, and to choose differently.

Give yourself time, consider whether boundaries are respected, and seek perspective from people you trust. **You don't have to reject a feeling to examine it, or act on it simply because it feels compelling.**

C. Respect Autonomy

Vulnerability isn't an invitation to romantic or sexual attention. You never owe anyone personal information, intimacy, or continued contact.

You can say no, change your mind, or disengage without owing anyone an explanation. Others have that same freedom.

Your needs and desires are legitimate, but they don't obligate anyone else. Consider the other person's wellbeing as well as your own. Healthy connection respects everyone's freedom to choose.

Respect others' choices without demanding explanations or pressuring them to reconsider. You can honor your own disappointment without assuming what their decision means about you.

Mind your influence. Differences in experience, confidence, recovery, or social standing can give us considerable influence over others. The more influence we have, the greater our responsibility to exercise it with care.

You can't ultimately control another person's feelings, but you are responsible for how you use your influence. **Greater experience calls for greater care, not greater authority over someone else's choices.**

Be honest about what you want and can offer. Don't cultivate expectations you don't intend to honor, or use someone's reliance on you to obtain intimacy, reassurance, or compliance. State your own limits honestly rather than using support or approval as leverage.

Leave room for time, questions, other relationships, and outside perspectives. Respect signs that your attention isn't wanted. Be willing to change course, including when the attention you are receiving feels good.

D. Reach Out and Speak Up

Whether something feels wrong or you simply want another perspective, talk it over with someone you trust: a friend, sponsor, group trusted servant, or appropriate professional.

You can seek perspective on how someone is treating you, how you are treating them, or a pattern developing between you. You don't need to be certain that anyone has done something wrong before seeking support.

You don't have to determine someone's motives before deciding to pause, decline, seek support, or leave.

Sometimes the next step is setting a boundary, sometimes it's disengaging, sometimes it's working through discomfort, sometimes it's attempting repair, and sometimes it's asking for help addressing harmful behavior.

As you learn more, you can change your understanding or choose a different response. Support can help you decide whether repair is appropriate; you don't have to attempt it before seeking protection.

If someone crosses your boundaries, you are not alone, and you are not to blame for their behavior. You deserve support even if you didn't recognize the problem, found it hard to say no, or are still unsure what happened.

D. Reach Out and Speak Up (continued)

Responding to Concerns with Care

If you notice behavior that concerns you, even when you're not directly involved, you can seek perspective or speak with a trusted servant. You don't need to establish someone's intentions or prove wrongdoing before raising a concern.

How we respond to concerns matters not only for safety, but for everyone's opportunity to recover.

Observe behavior without taking someone else's inventory. Describe what you saw or heard and what concerns you. Distinguish observations from interpretations, without diagnosing character defects, assigning motives, or deciding what kind of person someone is. We can take behavior seriously without reducing someone to their behavior.

Offer a mirror, not a verdict. When appropriate, we can privately reflect what we've observed, listen to the other person's perspective, and invite them to consider the effects of their behavior. We can't work someone else's program, but sometimes a compassionate reflection helps someone recognize a pattern and choose differently. We don't have to convince them, correct them, or take responsibility for what they do with that perspective. We can also be willing to hear what others notice about us.

Seek help, not an audience. Raising a concern can be an act of care. Ask yourself: *Am I seeking perspective, offering support, or protecting someone, or am I recruiting people to take sides?* When concerns become gossip or judgments about someone's character, we risk isolating people from the very community where they're trying to heal and grow. Share relevant concerns with care and discretion, involving people who can offer support or help address them.

Discretion isn't silence. We can respect someone's dignity and opportunity for recovery while taking harmful behavior seriously. Sometimes that means a private conversation; sometimes it means involving trusted servants or taking protective action. Nobody is obligated to confront someone who has harmed them, and protecting others may require speaking more widely when appropriate.

Staying connected to recovery doesn't require staying in a relationship or meeting that harms you. If one person cannot offer the support you need, you can approach someone else.

You don't have to navigate difficult experiences alone. Reach out. Connection is part of recovery.

Safety Card

MA's Safety Card complements these principles with guidance for recognizing safety concerns, seeking support, and helping groups maintain safe, welcoming meetings.

MA Safety Card: MA12.org/safetycard

Our Primary Purpose

Guided by Traditions Three and Five, our goal isn't to judge who's worthy of recovery. It's to foster a community where everyone has the opportunity to pursue it, even when some of us are still sick and suffering.

Everyone deserves a chance at recovery. Everyone deserves to feel safe seeking it.

An independent, member-created resource for navigating relationships in recovery. Not an official publication of Marijuana Anonymous.